HILCHOT SHABBAT

What Can You Still Do at Twilight on Friday?

Given Thursday 12 November 2026 · Hilchot Shabbat | Siman 261:1

Sefer: Shulhan Arukh, Orah Hayim, Hilchot Shabbat **Siman:** 261, seif 1 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Thursday Hilchot Shabbat class, Thursday 15 June 2023

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Three introductions

Siman 261 deals with the time for lighting and the start of Shabbat. The Rabbi gave three introductions.

1. When is twilight? Between day and night is bein hashemashot, twilight. - **The Geonim**, followed by the Rambam, Rashi and most Rishonim: twilight begins at sunset and ends when three stars appear. There is a small question whether sunset means the sun going behind the buildings or fully below the horizon, a difference of a few minutes; this is why, for example, a woman whose check was done a few minutes after sunset should ask, as there may be room to be lenient. - **Rabbeinu Tam**, Rashi's grandson: twilight begins about 58.5 minutes after what we call sunset and lasts three quarters of a mil, so that nightfall is 72 minutes after sunset. In practice, in the summer Rabbeinu Tam ends Shabbat slightly earlier than our calendars; in the winter about 20 minutes later.

The Rabbi noted that Rabbeinu Tam lived in France, where summer evenings stay light for a long time. In Israel, 50 minutes after sunset it is pitch dark, so the opinion is hard to reconcile with what one sees there. The big question, for next week, is that here the Shulhan Arukh seems to rule like Rabbeinu Tam, and elsewhere like the Geonim.

2. Twilight is a doubt. It is safek yom, safek laylah, so we are strict on both ends. That is why Shabbat lasts about 25 hours. Some later authorities argue that twilight has its own status, neither day nor night.

3. From twilight, no Torah Melakhah. The question is what about rabbinic prohibitions. Normally a doubt in a rabbinic law is lenient. Yet here most rabbinic prohibitions remain forbidden, with a few specific exceptions.

What is forbidden at twilight

The Shulhan Arukh (from the Mishnah "Bameh Madlikin" we say on Friday night): - **Separating maaser from produce that is certainly untithed,** because it changes the status of the food. - **Immersing vessels** to purify them (relevant to the laws of purity, not to us today). - **Lighting the candles.** - **Making an Eruv Tehumin** (for walking beyond the Shabbat limit).

The Rabbi pointed out that the Shulhan Arukh includes items that are no longer relevant, because it quotes a complete list from the Mishnah. "When you said Bameh Madlikin last Friday night, I hope you thought of what we learnt on Thursday night."

Not sure whether it is twilight yet?

The Mishnah Berurah: even if you are unsure whether twilight has begun, these remain forbidden. Why is this not a double doubt (sefek sefeka)? Two important principles:

- **A doubt from your own lack of knowledge is not a doubt.** Not knowing the time because you have no watch is not a safek. A real safek is where no one knows, for example who the halacha follows.
- **A double doubt needs two separate doubts.** "Is it twilight yet?" and "Is twilight day or night?" are really one big doubt: is it day or night?

He gave examples of real double doubts: - **Restaurant food and bishul akum.** Sefaradim require a Jew to do a third of the cooking; Ashkenazim rely on a Jew lighting the fire. Sefaradim may still eat cooked food in an Ashkenazi-supervised restaurant, because there are two separate doubts: maybe the halacha is like the Rema, and maybe, as the Raavad holds, bishul akum does not apply to food cooked outside one's home commercially. Neither alone would be enough. The concern behind bishul akum is a non-Jew cooking for you in your home. - **Meat at an Ashkenazi host.** A Sefaradi may eat meat that is not Halak Beit Yosef at an Ashkenazi home: maybe the halacha is like the Rema, and maybe this animal was in fact halak. Not knowing which is not a "personal" doubt, since no one checked.

Tevilat kelim on Shabbat

A question arose: why is immersing a new vessel on Shabbat not "changing status"? The Gemara gives four reasons for not immersing an impure vessel on Shabbat: carrying, squeezing, delaying immersion until Shabbat, and that it looks like fixing a vessel. The Rif and Rambam rule by a reason that applies only to impure vessels. So the Shulhan Arukh (323:7) rules that a new vessel may be immersed on Shabbat, but a God-fearing person should be strict. The Rabbi: "We don't do it." If you need it, give the vessel to a non-Jew as a gift and borrow it back. If that is not possible, it is permitted to immerse it.

What is permitted at twilight

- **Separating maaser from demai**, produce of an am haares that was probably tithed.
- **Hatmanah,** wrapping a pot that was just on the fire. Normally one may not insulate on Shabbat because one might first reheat the food. At twilight it is still boiling hot, so there is no concern.
- **Eruv Haserot,** because it is a misvah: it unites the residents into one community for Shabbat. The Rabbi said there is no city eruv that is kosher according to all opinions, but making one is a misvah.

Why these exceptions and not every rabbinic law? Each listed item has a specific reason. The general principle remains that rabbinic prohibitions apply at twilight; otherwise, the Rabbi suggested, there would be an hour each week with no real Shabbat.

Telling a non-Jew at twilight

The Shulhan Arukh permits telling a non-Jew during twilight to do a Torah Melakhah for Shabbat needs, such as turning on a light. Telling a non-Jew is itself rabbinic, and at twilight we are dealing with a doubt.

The Rabbi linked this to siman 342: at twilight, rabbinic prohibitions are permitted for a misvah or a pressing need. His examples: - On Rosh Hashanah at twilight, if the shofar is in a tree, you may climb to fetch it (climbing is rabbinic), but not cut it. - His own example: if a television stays on, there is no non-Jew, and it will really disturb your Shabbat and your sleep, he argued that switching it off yourself during twilight would be permitted, as extinguishing electricity is rabbinic.

Friday only, or Saturday too? The Mishnah Berurah holds this applies only on Friday at twilight, not at the end of Shabbat, since Shabbat is then already established. Others apply it at both ends.

Practical summary

- From sunset (twilight) do no Melakhah, and treat rabbinic prohibitions as forbidden too.
- Not knowing the time is not a doubt: if unsure, act as if twilight has begun.
- At twilight you may still wrap a hot pot and make an Eruv Haserot.
- Do not immerse new vessels on Shabbat; give them to a non-Jew if needed.
- At twilight on Friday one may ask a non-Jew to do a Melakhah for Shabbat needs.
- Rabbinic acts for a misvah or great need at twilight: ask a rabbi for the case.

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